

WONDERLAND

COMICS • TOYS • COLLECTIBLES



The shop Wayne Barber opened in 1974

is still unlocked at 1409 N Van Ness. Tim is keeping the legacy.

A High Tower District street feature

Photographs and conversation recorded August 28, 2026

1409 N Van Ness Ave • Fresno, CA 93728 • (559) 268-3950
Tuesday–Saturday 10 a.m.–5 p.m. • Closed Sunday & Monday

YES! WE ARE OPEN.

BUY • SELL • TRADE • PRESS



1409. Red door. Sticker armor. Clown on the mat.

The yellow banner on the security gate is the first thing you see: YES! We are Open! Then the name in black block letters — Wonderland Comics — the old 559.268.3950 number, and the three words every shop like this lives on: BUY SELL TRADE. Under it, a blue banner with a hydraulic press in the middle: Comic Book Pressing.

This is Van Ness Village, Tower District, ZIP 93728. Blocks south of Fresno City College. People still give directions by landmarks — the laundromat, Chinese food, the flower shop that has been there forever, whoever is still cutting hair at Paradise. The hanging red sign over the sidewalk is louder than the gate. A grinning cartoon tough in a hat leans out of the letters. COMICS!! TOYS!! COLLECTIBLES!!

Inside, the place is not a boutique. It is a warehouse that learned to smile. Long pine shelves run the wall with bagged and boarded books standing like a skyline. Glass cases hold Hot Wheels in rows so tight they look like a parking lot. Marvel Legends and GI Joe hang on slatwall. Masters of the Universe boxes stack toward the ceiling. A Midway cabinet sits in the aisle like it never left 1993. White longboxes labeled VENOM, MARVEL, SETS, CROSSOVERS cover the tables.

A man in a tank top and cap works the boxes. That is Tim. He has been keeping the lights on since 2016.

THE RECORD

1965 — Wayne Barber and Bruce Campiano sell comics at Sunnyside Swap Meet as “Bruce Wayne.”

1974 — Wonderland Comics opens at Belmont and Abby after Wayne graduates Fresno State.

1984 — The shop moves to 1409 N Van Ness and does not leave.

2016 — Strokes force Wayne off the day-to-day. The torch passes. He still comes in on good days.

August 2025 — Wayne dies at 82. The shop holds a farewell. Bruce Campiano comes. The banners stay up.

Wayne Barber built this. He had been reading since 1959. Before the shop he already owned something like thirty thousand books — every superhero title from every company he could get his hands on from '59 to the day he unlocked the door. After Fresno State he found fifty people ahead of him for every job he applied for. The opportunity to open a shop opened instead. He jumped.

The Fresno Bee filmed him in 2015 for a series called Fresno Famous. The video description called him Comic Book Guy. People in town still say the Simpsons character was him — that the writers took his likeness and never sent a check. Official Simpsons history says Comic Book Guy is a composite: “every comic-book store guy in America.” Fresno never cared about the official history. Wayne was the guy. Knowledge like a card catalog. Customers treated like family. On good days after the strokes he would still come in, sit among the books, and talk.



Wall of boarded books. Pressing banner in the back.



Counter cases: die-cast cars, figures, the working desk.



Wonderland is a back-issue house on purpose. The shop advertises more than 300,000 older and rarer comics. If you need it, they will try to find it. The walls and pegboard are the other half of the business: vintage toys and the lines kids actually remember — He-Man, G.I. Joe, Transformers, Marvel Legends, Hot Wheels, horror kits, Twilight Zone, POW. A Midway Mortal Kombat cabinet stands in the aisle between the longboxes and the clock.

Tim added the pressing service — the blue banner on the gate is not decoration. Books get flattened and cleaned so they can live another decade in a bag and board. Reviews call him Timmy, “a straight-up no-BS guy.” The shop that had drifted got organized. It is still dense. It is no longer a cave.



What it costs to keep a door unlocked on this block

The conversation in the shop and on the sidewalk was not about first appearances and CGC grades. It was about the cost of doing business on Van Ness in 2026. Broken windows. Trash. Needles. A man behind a dumpster. Ladies standing and talking for an hour. The difference between a person down on luck and a person committing a crime on the sidewalk in front of a comic shop.

Landlords eat five to eight thousand dollars every time the glass goes. That bill does not stay on the landlord. It shows up in the rent, in the hours, in whether the next shop signs a lease. Clubs that used to hold a music scene get pulled out of the district. The 1990s Tower that Tim and the visitor both remember — skateboarders, punks, hippies, a community that ran trouble off fast — is not the same street. The observation from the counter: some criminal activity, not every hour, worse toward downtown and the south, and the fix that actually works is the unglamorous one. Keep it cleaned up. People will come if it looks like somebody cares.

“I have no problem with the homeless. The problem is the trash, the windows, the needles, the guy who thinks the sidewalk is a bathroom. That is not a housing status. That is a crime. Broken windows. That is the whole theory.”

— from the counter conversation, Wonderland Comics, August 28, 2026

The visitor had just spoken at the Fresno Planning Commission the night before about the same subject — homelessness framed as crime and gift when it is crime, unused littering statutes, broken windows, whistleblow or go down. The shop is the field test. A comic store that has survived Belmont in the seventies, Van Ness since 1984, strokes, a founder’s funeral, and a city that will not pick up the sidewalk is not a metaphor. It is a ledger.

Wonderland is not a nostalgia museum. It still trades. It presses books. It runs Wonder Days and Wonder Rama shows at the American Legion on North First. Sidewalk vendors get invited to set a table free. That is how a fifty-year shop stays a shop instead of becoming a plaque.

Wayne's bet in 1974

was that Fresno would keep a comic shop.

Tim's bet in 2016 — and again after August 2025 —

is the same bet with worse sidewalks and higher electric bills.

The yellow banner is still up. The red hanging sign still leans over Van Ness. The Midway cabinet still takes up an aisle it has not earned by modern square-footage math. The longboxes are still full. That is the whole story. A man named Wayne stacked thirty thousand comics, opened a door, moved it once, and trusted another man to keep the door unlocked after his body quit. A year after the funeral the press is still in the window and the phone still rings 268-3950.

WONDERLAND COMICS

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Fresno, California 93728
Tower District / Van Ness Village

(559) 268-3950
Tuesday–Saturday 10:00 a.m. – 5:00 p.m.
Sunday & Monday closed

Vintage & rare back issues • Toys & collectibles
Comic book pressing • Buy / Sell / Trade
Wonder Days in-store • Wonder Rama at American Legion 509

Sources for the public record: Wonderland Comics Fresno (Facebook, Aug. 20, 2025); FOX26 / KMPH memorial coverage (Aug. 23, 2025); Fresno Bee “Fresno Famous” profile of Wayne Barber (2015); shop listings at 1409 N Van Ness Ave. The Comic Book Guy comparison is local folklore, not a Simpsons credit.

Photographs: Aaron Hightower, August 28, 2026. Conversation with Tim at the counter the same morning.

Written for the High Tower District record. Not an advertisement. A shop that stayed.

YES. WE ARE OPEN.